

Yongjai Yu

Ph.D. Student, Department of Political Science, University of California, Riverside

yongjai.yu@email.ucr.edu | yyu209@ucr.edu | yuyongj.ai | github.com/YongjaiYu

Education

University of California, Riverside

Riverside, CA

Ph.D. in Political Science

2022–Present

Dissertation: Strategic Unilateralism and Presidential Policy Choice

Committee: Kevin M. Esterling (Chair), Nick Weller, Nicholas G. Napolio, and Jon C. Rogowski

Seoul National University

Seoul, Korea

Master of Public Policy, Graduate School of Public Administration

February 2022

Thesis: A Study on the Role of Contract Legislation in the Legislative Process

Advisor: Jisuk Woo

Qualifying Exams: Public Policy Theory; Research Methodology

Korea University

Seoul, Korea

Bachelor of Arts in History, College of Liberal Arts

February 2016

Research Interests

Substantive: American political institutions, presidential power and unilateral action, partisan loyalty.

Methods: Text and multimodal analysis, measurement and validation, survey digital twins.

Research Affiliation

Laboratory for Technology, Communication and Democracy (TeCD-Lab)

University of California, Riverside

2026–Present

Director: Professor Kevin M. Esterling

Publications

Cho, Eunmi, Sinjae Kang, Kyusik Yang, **Yongjai Yu**, and Yoonseok Lee. 2024. “Measuring Legislators’ Ideology and Analyzing Ideological Differences Across Standing Committees Using Wordfish: Evidence from the Minutes of Standing Committee Meetings in the 19th and 20th National Assembly.” *Journal of Research Methodology*. KCI. In Korean.

Working Papers

What Are We Generalizing To? How Test Design Shapes Model Choice in Congressional Text Classification. With Eunseong Oh. Submitted to *Political Analysis*.

Not Every Presidential Directive Is Ideological: Classifying Ideological Content in Unilateral Action. Dissertation project, Chapter 1, Part I.

Measuring the Ideological Content of Presidential Directives Using Anchored Embedding Scaling. Dissertation project, Chapter 1, Part II.

When Conspiracy Belief Mobilizes Donors: Campaign Contributions in American Politics.

When Text Meets Image: Unlocking Frames of Political Videos with Multimodal CLIP. With Eunseong Oh. Presented at PolMeth 2025.

Works in Progress

Survey Digital Twins Project. With Eunseong Oh. Fidelity validation using ANES and CES data.

Fandom Politics: A Formal Theory of Unconditional Partisan Loyalty and Democratic Backsliding.

Korean National Assembly YouTube Communication. With Kyusik Yang. Multimodal analysis.

Measuring Regulatory Change Through Delegated Legislation: Evidence from Korean Presidential Decrees.

Collaborative Pedagogy at Minority-Serving Institutions. With Karina Alpayeva, Emmanoel Ferreira, Sarah Siddique, and Kim Yi Dionne.

Conference Presentations

Society for Political Methodology (PolMeth) 2026

- Poster presenter, “Measuring the Ideological Content of Presidential Directives Using Anchored Embedding Scaling.”

Society for Political Methodology (PolMeth) 2025

- Poster presenter, “When Sparse Beats Dense: Vocabulary Separability and Model Selection in Political Text Analysis.” With Eunseong Oh.
- Co-author, “When Text Meets Image: Unlocking Frames of Political Videos with Multimodal CLIP.” With Eunseong Oh.

Midwest Political Science Association (MPSA) 2025

- Presenter, “Not Every Unilateral Action Is Ideological: Ideological Content and the President’s Strategic Behavior.”

Research Software and Data Products

poljacc. Python package for vocabulary separability diagnostics in political text classification.

AES Explorer. Interactive explorer of presidential directives scaled with anchored embeddings.

Korean Presidential Decree Explorer. Searchable amendments to presidential decrees, 1988–March 2026.

Text Polarization Workbench. Interactive analysis of partisan vocabulary in U.S. congressional floor speeches.

Research Software Development

Prytaneum

September 2026–Present

Web Development Team, TeCD-Lab, University of California, Riverside
AI-assisted platform for deliberative public engagement.

Teaching Experience

Summer Quant Camp

Summer 2026

Instructor, University of California, Riverside

Foundational statistics and R for incoming graduate students.

MacREU

Summer 2026

Instructor, University of California, Riverside
Guest lectures on data literacy, presentations, poster design, and abstract writing (MacREU/MEMENCYS).

Teaching Assistant

University of California, Riverside Riverside, CA
October 2023–Present

- **Graduate:** Survey of Quantitative Methods (POSC 202A); Survey of Quantitative Methods (POSC 202B)
- **Undergraduate:** American Politics (POSC 010); Comparative Politics (POSC 015); Politics of the Global South (POSC 017); Regulation: A Political Perspective (POSC 186); Politics and Economic Policy: American Politics (POSC 182E)

Fellowships, Grants, and Awards

- Gabbert Research Funding, Department of Political Science, UC Riverside (\$2,000)
- PolMeth 2025 Emory Travel Grant
- UC Riverside Chancellor’s Distinguished Fellowship Award
- GSA Travel Grant

Research Community, Service, and Training

Founder, Political Science Quantitative Methods Group Riverside, CA
University of California, Riverside June 2023–Present
Graduate methods group for research feedback and discussion of political methodology.

Member, Identity & Politics Lab Riverside, CA
University of California, Riverside January 2025–Present

Participant, SICSS-Korea Daejeon, Korea
Summer Institute in Computational Social Science July 2024
KAIST and KDI School of Public Policy and Management

Skills

Programming and Statistical Analysis: R, Python
Typesetting and Reproducible Writing: L^AT_EX
Methods: Bayesian statistics; causal inference; text analysis; large language models; deep learning; multimodal analysis

References

Kevin M. Esterling
Professor and Chair, Department of Political Science
University of California, Riverside
kevin.esterling@ucr.edu